if they are beneficiaries of the trust, they don't have the right to dissolve it. Putting your house in a trust forces you to define exactly who gets what before there's a divorce or a death in the family. If you and your spouse get embroiled in a nasty custody battle someday, your assets will be protected. The trustees won't get emotional about who did what to whom. Their job is simply to follow the rules you and your partner mutually agreed on from the get-go.

I don't care how much money you've got, putting your home into a trust is a great way to protect your biggest asset. It's an excellent tool for the family dynasty because if forces you to have a healthy discussion about what could and should happen down the road. A trust makes you deal with the future today.

There are other strategies for protecting your assets, so you'll want to consult your lawyer and/or financial advisor about the options available to you. Again, it's all a matter of being financially aware the minute you're married—and preferably long before.

Money Mistake: *You Think You and Your Partner Are Exempt Because You're Different*

The Fix: *Same-Sex and Common-Law Partnerships—Same Rules Apply*

Everything I'm saying goes for same-sex couples and common-law partners as well. Keep your money safe, no matter whom you shack up with. Whether you get married in a church, a courthouse or on the island of Tahiti; whether you get hitched to a man or a woman; whether your marriage license is hot off the press or you're joined together by common law; the financial implications are identical. Each person in the relationship should have his or her own bank account and his or her independent financial advisor. If you're building a life together, build it together financially. Work hard to grow your financial dynasty, and put assets in both of your names. That's the tie that binds.

Build your partnership the way you'd build a business: with sound financial decisions and investments of both money and time. Why